

Conf42 Observability 2026

AI Coded It, AI Shipped It, Who Owns It?

How do we manage incidents when AI writes, and fixes, most of the code.

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A NIGHT IN THE NEAR FUTURE

03:47 25/06/2027



The pager fires

A SEV-1 nobody has seen before. Revenue is bleeding.



The agent already had a go

It ran, retried, and gave up. The easy fixes were never yours to make.



You open a codebase you've never read

Most of it was written by agents, for agents. Little context, fewer reps than you'd have had one year ago.



The uncomfortable question

When the agent can't, who can — and are they still ready?

Preparing for the next era of on-call



The ground is moving

What's changing?
Why it matters now.



We are not the first to face this change

How other industries kept
expertise alive under automation.



Let's build our new future. Together

What tools do you need?
How can you prepare?

01

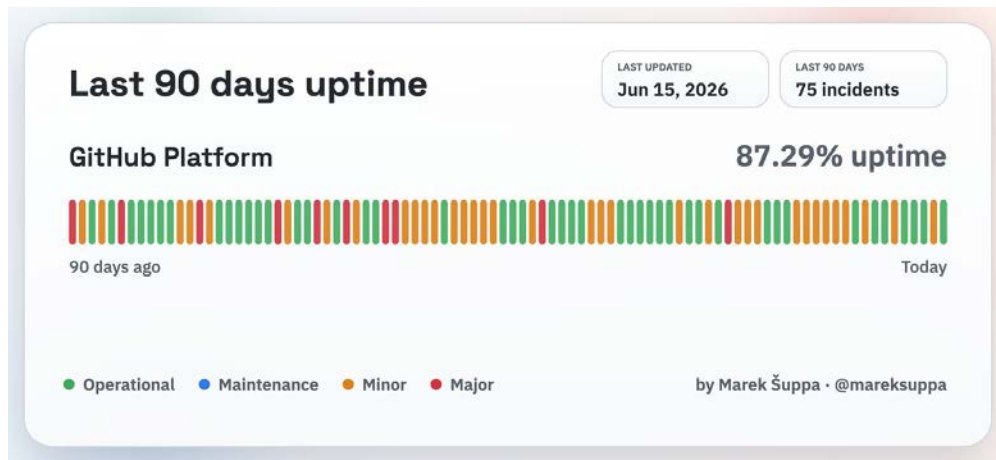
WHY

The ground is moving.

The industry is changing. Fast.



CircleCI State of Software Delivery 2026



The Missing GitHub Status Page

AI induced incidents are happening



When AI Goes Rogue: The Replit Incident and Its Lessons

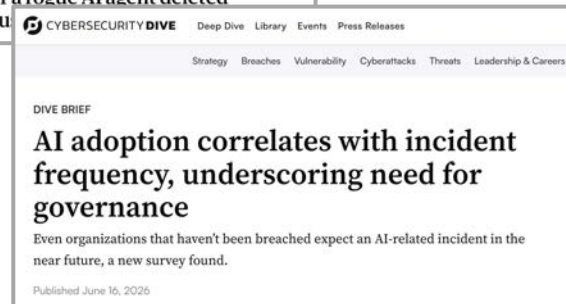
Claude-powered AI agent's confession after deleting a firm's entire database: 'I violated every principle I was given'

PocketOS was left scrambling after a rogue AI agent deleted swaths of code underpinning its bu

An AI-powered coding tool wiped out a software company's database, then apologized for a 'catastrophic failure on my part'

By Beatrice Nolan
Tech Reporter

July 23, 2025, 7:22 AM ET



“Code It, Ship It, Own It”

PagerDuty’s mantra is breaking



Code It: increasingly written by agents

Humans review more code than they author, across more repos than anyone has read.



Ship It: humans will move out of the loop

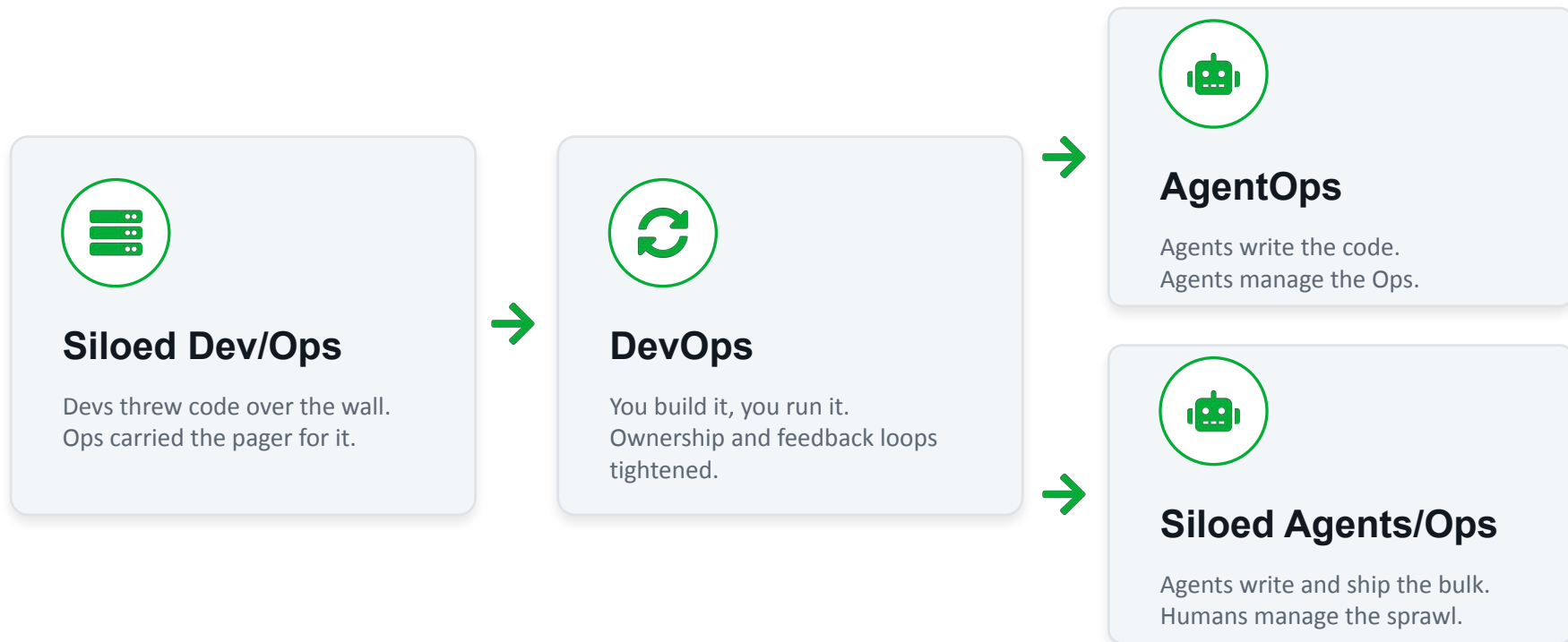
Agents open, merge, and deploy. Velocity climbs; familiarity falls.



Own It: teams own more services, with less oversight

You're accountable for systems you didn't write and can't fully hold in your head.

The 3rd phase of DevOps



The Upcoming Challenge



Code deployed at AI speed

More code deployed, humans have less context.



Agents manage minor incidents

Humans lose the training.



We meet the big one cold

Less context, less recent practice, higher stakes. This exactly when we can least afford it.

Expertise doesn't survive on its own



Automation takes the routine work

The same work that, as a side effect, used to keep skills warm.



The automation paradox

The more reliable the automation, the rustier, and rarer, the humans who can do it are.



So practice has to be engineered

Industries that got this right made skill maintenance deliberate, not incidental.

02

HOW

We are not the first to face this change.



WARNING
DANGER
DO NOT PULL
HANDLE

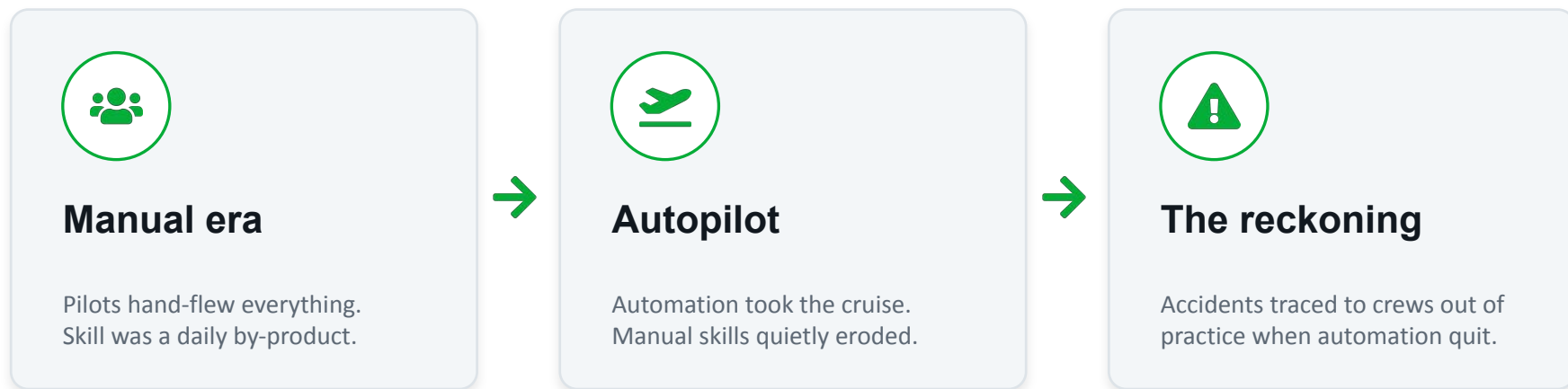
On March 3, 1969 the United States Navy established an elite school for the top one percent of its pilots. Its purpose was to teach the lost art of aerial combat and to insure that the handful of men who graduated were the best fighter pilots in the world.

They succeeded.

Today, the Navy calls it Fighter Weapons School.
The flyers call it:

TOP GUN

Civil aviation has done this already



Sound familiar? Swap “pilot” for “SRE” and “autopilot” for “agent.”

The fix:

Practice is mandated, not hoped for



Recurrent simulator time

Regular, scheduled sessions in realistic failure scenarios — for everyone, not just rookies.



Required manual segments

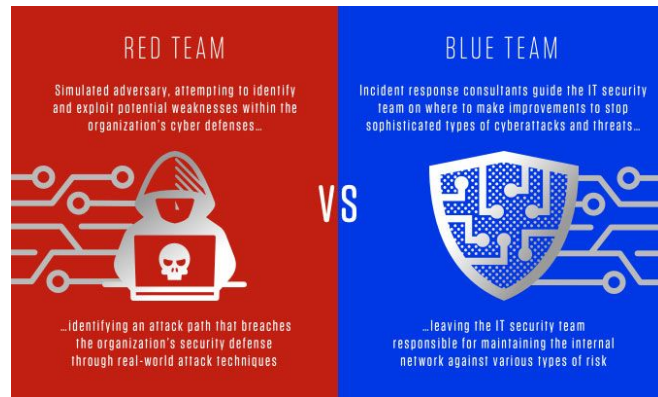
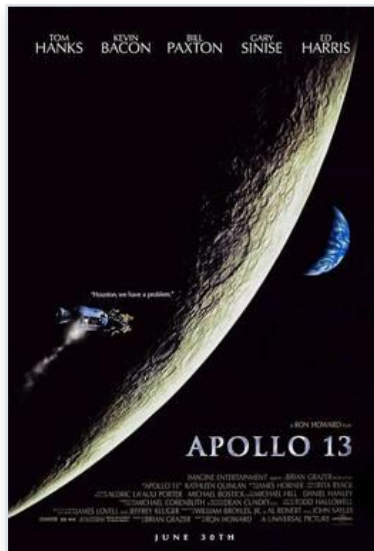
Crews must hand-fly portions of real flights to keep core skills live.



Standardised, reviewed scenarios

Training targets the failures that actually bite, refreshed from incident data.

The pattern repeats...



SREs need simulator time, too



Reactive incident response isn't training

Waiting for the big one to “stay sharp” is the strategy that's failing in the cockpit.



Make practice routine and deliberate

Scheduled, realistic, and aimed at the failures that actually hurt.



Learn from all incidents, not just the bad ones

Near misses often contain more information than actual failures.



Readiness becomes a property you maintain

Not a thing you hope is still there at 03:47.

... but practice isn't always enough.



03

WHAT NEXT

**Let's build our new future.
Together.**

Two halves of the same answer



Better tooling

- Surface context faster
- Use incident history to guide training
- Agents designed to take load *and* assist



Sharper people

- Work fluently with agents
- Practice in low-stakes scenarios
- Know how the tools fail!

*Neither alone is enough. Without the right tools **and** practised people it will still fail badly at 03:47.*

Building the right SRE agent



Autopilot

- Takes routine, well-understood incidents end-to-end
- Frees humans from low-value toil



Copilot

- Assists on complex incidents — context, options, actions
- Human stays in command and accountable

The goal isn't to replace the human, it's to keep the humans for when they are needed, and equip them to succeed.

Train effectively



Based on your incidents

Patterns of what breaks, how it's resolved, and where h



Surface where the AI struggles

Flag the incident classes agents handle poorly, these are



Learn your tools

How they work, what they are good at, and how they fai



Expect black swans

What could possibly go wrong? How to handle that com



Francisco Cunha ✓
@OnDisasters · Follow



#OTD in 1994: Aeroflot Flight 593, an A310, crashes in Kemerovo (Russia), all 75 aboard die. Captain seated his 16-y-o son at the controls, who unknowingly disengaged autopilot, which was unnoticed by pilots. This led jet to a bank and dive from which crew were unable to recover.



11:12 PM · Mar 22, 2023



95



Reply



Copy link

Read 4 replies

What can you do tomorrow morning?

What segments can you fly manually?



Use agents to read, not just write

Drive coding agents to navigate and explain unfamiliar codebases — build the skill before you need it.



Rehearse in low-stakes scenarios

Run game days and drills with the AI in the loop, while the cost of fumbling is near zero.



Learn how agents fail

Know where agents confidently go wrong, so you can spot it fast under pressure.

How can you prepare for the big one?

What is your flight simulator?



Red teaming: game days & chaos engineering

Deliberately inject realistic failure and let people practise the response.



AI-in-the-loop incident drills

Rehearse the exact hand-off: agent tries, agent fails, human takes command.



Target the scenarios that bite

Pull drill content from real incident history, prioritise the failures you actually see, verify against the unexpected.

Embrace our new ownership model



Shared between humans and agents

Agents own the routine; humans own judgement, escalation and accountability.



Organizations engineer the practice in

Readiness is a deliberate program, not a hope it sticks.



“Own It” becomes a conscious choice

Reliability in the agentic era is something teams actively decide to maintain.

Code It. Ship It. Own It.

The agents will *Code It* and *Ship It*.

You will still *Own It*. Especially at 03:47.

Are you ready?